should we do it if it helped extend the life of Communism? It was a dilemma I had to deal with during my first months in the White House.

We were also faced by another serious dilemma: How do we stop the advance of Communism in Latin America without making the people of Latin America think Uncle Sam is a bigger threat to them than the Communists?

A few days after the inauguration, our intelligence agents obtained firm and incontrovertible evidence that the Marxist government of Nicaragua was transferring hundreds of tons of Soviet arms from Cuba to rebel groups in El Salvador. Although El Salvador was the immediate target, the evidence showed that the Soviets and Fidel Castro were targeting all of Central America for a Communist takeover. El Salvador and Nicaragua were only a down payment. Honduras, Guatemala, and Costa Rica were next, and then would come Mexico.

The plans had been in the archives of Communism for a long time. I had been told that Lenin once said, “First, we will take Eastern Europe, then we will organize the hordes of Asia . . . then we will move on to Latin America; once we have Latin America, we won’t have to take the United States, the last bastion of capitalism, because it will fall into our outstretched hands like overripe fruit.”

We had already lost Cuba to Communism. I was determined the Free World was not going to lose Central America or more of the Caribbean to the Communists, but we had to tread softly. In the minds of many people in Latin America, the United States was the “Great Colossus of the North” that in the past had been too willing to send in the marines and interfere with their governments. The prospect of American troops being dispatched across their borders to fight Communism was abhorrent to these people. And after Vietnam, I knew that Americans would be just as reluctant